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Newsom Signs Safe Worship Act, Ira Gershwin Initiative, Technion Society Names Board President

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Less than a year after a protest outside Wilshire Blvd. Temple turned violent, California Gov. Gavin Newsom (D) returned to that same sanctuary to sign the law it inspired.

Newsom signed AB 2664, the Safe Worship Zone Act, in a ceremony at the historic LA synagogue, joined by Jewish California CEO David Bocarsly; Board Chair Debi Graboff; clergy and leadership of Wilshire Boulevard Temple; six members of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus – Asms. Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), Rebecca Bauer-Kahan (D-Orinda), Josh Lowenthal (D-Long Beach) and Rick Chavez Zbur (D-Hollywood) and State Sens. Ben Allen (D-El Segundo) and Henry Stern (D-Sherman Oaks) – and leaders of the bill's cosponsoring organizations: Tye Gregory of JCRC Bay Area, Rabbi Noah Farkas and Joanna Mendelson of Jewish Federation Los Angeles, and David Englin of ADL LA.

AB 2664 establishes a 100-foot zone around the entrances of houses of worship, inside which no one may approach a congregant within eight feet without consent to hand out literature, display a sign, or otherwise obstruct, harass, or intimidate them. It is modeled on Colorado's buffer-zone law protecting reproductive health clinics, upheld by the U.S. Supreme Court, and balances two co-equal First Amendment protections: right to worship and right to protest.

"Every Californian, no matter their faith, will now be able to walk to their place of worship without fear of being surrounded or intimidated," Bocarsly said. "Governor Newsom signing this bill alongside Jewish California and our partners speaks to the depth of the relationship we have built together, and to how seriously he takes the safety of every Californian who gathers to practice their faith. We're grateful to Assemblymember Bauer-Kahan, the Jewish Caucus, and our interfaith partners for standing behind this effort."

At the signing ceremony, Newsom also signed Assembly Bill 1836, authored by Gabriel and sponsored by Jewish California and Equality California. The bill expands the California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program to cover offsite community events – menorah lightings, Pride celebrations, cultural festivals – closing a gap that had limited funding to a nonprofit's own physical building. It passed the Senate unanimously and the Assembly 78-0, with one abstention.

"California is stepping up to protect our communities, so that Californians of all faiths and backgrounds can gather together and celebrate without fear," Gabriel, chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, said. "This bill sends a powerful message that California will continue to stand with the LGBTQ+ community and all others targeted by hate. We will never let hate win." Both laws take effect Jan. 1, 2027.

The Ira and Leonore S. Gershwin Philanthropic Fund is the new named sponsor of Creative Community for Peace's (CCFP) Vanguard Initiative, now the Ira Gershwin Vanguard Initiative. Ira Gershwin wrote lyrics that helped define the Great American Songbook, which makes him a fitting namesake for a program that trains the next generation of entertainment leaders. Vanguard gives young entertainment professionals the knowledge and connections to understand the challenges facing the Jewish people, how to confront antisemitism and anti-Israel bigotry, and lead in their industry.

The program held its inaugural event under the new name on Sept. 17. About 150 industry leaders and young professionals turned out to the Beverly Hills home of Blair and David Kohan for a WGA Jewish affinity group panel. The speakers were David Kohan ("Will and Grace"), Jamie Denbo ("Grey's Anatomy"), Leslie Schapira ("Creature

Commandos"), and Jeff Astrof ("Friends"). They discussed what pitching Jewish or Israeli stories means for writers' careers in today's environment.

The American Technion Society (ATS), a community of donors and alumni across the United States that supports the Technion – Israel Institute of Technology, announced that Janet Shatz has begun her term as national board president. Shatz was elected by the organization's national board of directors.

"Janet has been a valued member of the ATS family for decades, and her determination, vision, and deep personal knowledge of the Technion make her the ideal leader for the board at this moment," Mark Gaines, former national board president and current chair of the ATS board of directors, said.

Shatz will work alongside ATS and Technion leadership to grow giving at a time when the university's scientific innovation is more critical than ever to global progress and the future of the State of Israel. A second-generation supporter, her connection to the Technion runs deep — from her first visit to the Haifa campus in her 20s, through years of regional leadership, national board service, financial governance and investment stewardship. She has served on the national board of directors for 12 years and was president of ATS – Washington, D.C. from 2019-22. As national board president, she plans to focus particularly on strengthening multi-generational connections to the Technion, drawn from her own family's history with the institution.

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